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Section Title(S): The Effect Of Kinship On Reciprocity

The point at which reciprocity ceases to be an automatic obligation of kinship varies from society to society and may not be clear within any one—for some the limit is with the primary ties, for others with grandparent's descendants. Whatever the limit, hunter-gatherers are hesitant to show preference for relatives beyond it. In order to keep as many relationships as possible “warm” (Anderson 1968), the success of doing this hinges on two factors, (1) convenient “forgetting” of details of genealogy and teaching children their relatives according to a kin term, not a specific consanguineous or affinal tie, and (2) having systems by which kin terms can be extended to non-kin or quasi-kin, specifying a potential relationship as well as an expected range of behavior. Under this system, true kin are not ignored but all others with whom a person is likely to interact become kinsmen.

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Among the !Kung, distant and non-kin are brought closer by the factor of the name and the name relationship, but among their neighbors the /Gwi this is done by a system of classificatory kinship that is flexible enough so that everybody a /Gwi meets can be classified as a kinsman (Silberbauer 1972). The Eskimo do not seem to  356 have quite the flexible kinship system of the /Gwi, but isolate the immediate family and merge collaterals in cousin designations. However, Gubser (1965) says that among the Nunamiut, any two individuals who can identify a common kinsman, no matter how distant, have a kin term for one another. If it is not possible for them to find a common relative other channels are still open—a name relationship, a dancing partnership, joking partnership, etc.. With all these means at hand, it is possible for almost any two individuals to establish a foundation for a more binding partnership, in other words, to take each other out of the feared category of stranger.

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